FUNDING

How do I pay for home modifications in Florida?

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Original Medicare generally does not pay for grab bars, raised toilet seats, shower chairs, ramps or stair lifts. Help does exist, though. Veterans benefits, Area Agencies on Aging, state programs and nonprofits can cover some or all of the cost, and many of the most important fixes cost little or nothing.

What Medicare does and does not cover

It helps to separate equipment from changes to the house.

- **Durable medical equipment (DME):** walkers, canes, wheelchairs and hospital beds may be covered under Medicare Part B when a clinician orders them and a Medicare-enrolled supplier provides them. You usually pay about 20% coinsurance after the Part B deductible.
- **Bathroom safety items and home modifications:** grab bars, raised toilet seats, shower chairs, ramps and stair lifts are generally not covered by Original Medicare.
- **Medicare Advantage and Medicaid:** some Medicare Advantage plans and some Medicaid waiver programs do help with these items. Call your plan and ask what it covers before you buy.

You can read Medicare's own page on durable medical equipment coverage. If you are wondering about the visit itself, see Does Medicare pay for a home safety assessment?

Start with what is free

Before you look for funding, know that several high-value fixes cost almost nothing:

- Remove or secure throw rugs.
- Clear clutter and cords from walkways.
- Store daily-use items where no reaching, bending or climbing is needed.
- Keep a phone on the body at all times.

Motion sensor night lights in the bedroom, hallway and bathroom are another low-cost step. Doing these first means any outside money can go toward the bigger jobs, like grab bars installed into studs or rails on both sides of the stairs.

Veterans: the VA HISA grant

The VA Home Improvements and Structural Alterations (HISA) grant pays for medically necessary home changes. It is a lifetime benefit of up to $6,800 for changes needed because of a service-connected condition (or for any condition if the veteran has a service-connected rating of at least 50%), or up to $2,000 for other conditions. Ask the veteran's VA doctor or the local VA Prosthetic and Sensory Aids Service about applying, and read the details on the VA HISA page.

Florida and Tampa Bay sources of help

These agencies are good first calls. Each can tell you what is available where your parent lives.

- **Elder Helpline: 1-800-963-5337.** This statewide line from the Florida Department of Elder Affairs connects you with your local Area Agency on Aging.
- **Senior Connection Center:** the Area Agency on Aging for Hillsborough, Polk, Hardee, Highlands and Manatee counties (business line 813-740-3888).
- **Area Agency on Aging of Pasco-Pinellas:** 727-217-8111.
- **Hillsborough County Aging Services:** (813) 272-5250.
- **FAAST** (Florida Alliance for Assistive Services and Technology): loan and reuse programs for assistive technology, 844-353-2278. Borrowing a device first is a smart way to learn whether it works before you buy.
- **Rebuilding Together:** a nonprofit that does home repairs through local affiliates.

Area Agencies on Aging can also explain programs paid for by the Older Americans Act (Title III) and Florida's Community Care for the Elderly program. Outside Florida, the Eldercare Locator (1-800-677-1116) finds the local agency for any address.

For a parent with low vision, Florida's Division of Blind Services may help with the cost of devices. The Tampa district office can be reached at 800-757-7190.

Questions to ask any program

- Who is eligible (age, income, disability, veteran status)?
- Does the program pay the contractor directly, or reimburse you?
- Is there a waiting list?
- Do you need a written recommendation from a therapist or doctor?

That last question matters. Many programs ask for proof that a change is needed. A written report from a clinician who has seen the person move through the home can make an application stronger.

Spend the money in the right order

Money goes furthest when it follows a plan. Rank the changes by risk first, then by cost. The bathroom and the night route from bed to toilet usually come first, because that walk is the highest-risk trip of the day.

Hire qualified installers for grab bars, rails, ramps and electrical work. For larger projects, a Certified Aging-in-Place Specialist (CAPS) remodeler can help. Be careful with offers of a free inspection from a company that also sells the fix; see Is a free contractor home safety check really free?

How Home Safety Solutions can help

A home safety visit gives you a written report with prioritized findings, ranked from free changes to larger projects, plus clear notes on what Medicare and other programs may or may not cover and local funding resources. Home Safety Solutions takes no referral fees from contractors, suppliers or vendors, so the advice stays unbiased. Learn what happens during a home safety visit. Call (813) 365-9171 or email info@homesafety.solutions.

Related reading: Does Medicare pay for a home safety assessment? · Is a free contractor home safety check really free? · What grab bars do I actually need in the bathroom? · FAAST · Is it normal to fall as you get older?

This article is general education, not medical advice. Talk with your doctor, pharmacist, or therapist about your own situation.

Want a plan for your own home?
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